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Elkton police defends use of Flock cameras as residents question transparency

Elkton police are defending their use of Flock Safety cameras, but some residents are concerned with the technology and their implementation.

By [Mason Willett](#)

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ELKTON, Va. (WHSV) - Elkton police are defending their use of Flock Safety cameras — license plate reading technology designed to help investigate crimes and locate missing people. However, some residents say the issue isn't just the cameras; it's how they were brought into the community.

The license plate reading system was installed in 2024, using Virginia State Police [HEAT grant funding](#). However, Zachary Caudle, an Elkton resident, said he didn't learn about the three cameras until four months ago.

"The biggest concern I have about it is the transparency from the town and the police department," Caudle said. "It seemed like it was done purposely behind everyone's head and no one knew about it."

Caudle said he believes the cameras collect more than just license plates, pointing to what Flock calls vehicle fingerprinting, which can identify vehicles by features like dents, stickers, or body damage. He argues that amount of data creates privacy concerns and said he would like the cameras removed.

"I don't think a town of this size, a peaceful town. Everyone here is so nice, just doesn't need something like that for policing," Caudle said. "The town manager basically signed a terms of service box for the residents of 3,000 people without our consent, and we have no way to opt out of it."

Elkton Police Sgt. Ryan Insana called that description misleading and said the cameras are used only for legitimate criminal justice purposes under Virginia law. As for the town manager's decision, Insana said since the purchase was less than \$30,000 and was paid for using grants, the town council didn't have to vote on this.

"We can't just get on there and look at Joe Smith who lives on B Street in town and see where he travels," Insana said. "We can't do that. It's a class 1 misdemeanor if we were to do that."

Insana said the town tries to be transparent with the Flock cameras, including with a [transparency portal on their website](#), which shows data over a three-week period and policies for the use of the cameras.

“If this one tool can help us solve crimes more efficiently and get justice for victims, then we’ll continue to use it until we’re told otherwise,” he said.

Insana said the equipment would also have prevented issues with investigations for the Subway and gun store break-ins where no cameras or eyewitnesses were around.

“With the attempted breaking and entering, our case went kind of cold on that, so we put it there to mitigate future incidences. If an incident does occur, then at least we have somewhere to look into,” Insana said. “If we would have had that technology or this technology then, maybe it would have given us a starting point to see what that vehicle was.”

While Insana said the technology is carefully regulated and used to improve public safety, residents like Caudle continue to push for more answers and greater public discussion about how this technology is used in Elkton.

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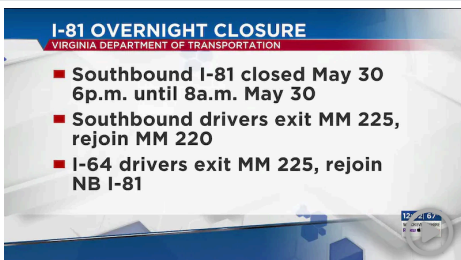
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